

Phantom Island?

Sandy Island, located in the Coral Sea as shown by Google Earth, does not exist. Explorers searched the area for 25 days but found no trace of any island

Space junk problem resolution

Scientists at University of Glasgow have developed the Aerodynamic End of Life Deorbit System (AEOLDOS) which will ensure objects sent in space can be removed at the end of their operational cycle.

Earth's magnetosphere, and high-energy radiation from the sun or other sources will wreck havoc on our bodies, needing us to continually wear protective clothing whenever we are "outdoors". Another issue is the absence of any directional frame of reference. With no direction to call "up", we would need to rely on artificial cues to find our way both within our spacecraft and across space. Furthermore, our sense of time itself would be in for a major revolution. With no sun and moon in interstellar space to constantly remind us of the passage of time, we would have to abandon our 24-hour clocks, and mould ourselves to shorter or longer working hours – whichever suit our current surroundings.

To counter these ill effects, human bodies could be placed in long periods of hibernation. By slowing down metabolism rates to almost zero, mechanically massaging sleeping bodies, and closely monitoring all life-critical parameters, we should be able to preserve human life. However, it would be a rude awakening once the spaceship is close to its destination, and a busy few hours initially, as the first order of business would be to acclimatize and rapidly educate oneself of the planet, moon, or spaceport and its inhabitants.

Given that chemical-based rockets are an extremely inefficient means of transportation (low power-to-weight ratios result in huge rockets carrying small payloads), we could of course "speed up" our journeys



The world inside a cylndrical planet

by adopting other means of propulsion. As a plasma drive is one such alternative, wherein gases such as xenon or krypton are ionized using an electrical source and the ions thus produced are emitted by subjecting them to a voltage. Higher speeds can simply be achieved by applying higher voltages to the plasma. Another idea still on the drawing board is to use a powerful laser and point it at a huge light reflecting surface attached to a payload. The impulse force created by photons hitting the sail should theoretically be enough to drive push a moderately heavy payload, slow at first but with constant acceleration approaching the speed of light. This method doesn't require the spacecraft to carry its own fuel, thus reducing its size and weight. When all else fails, we could go back to our Star Trek routes and bend space and time to our whims or use wormholes and hyperspace to instantly appear at our

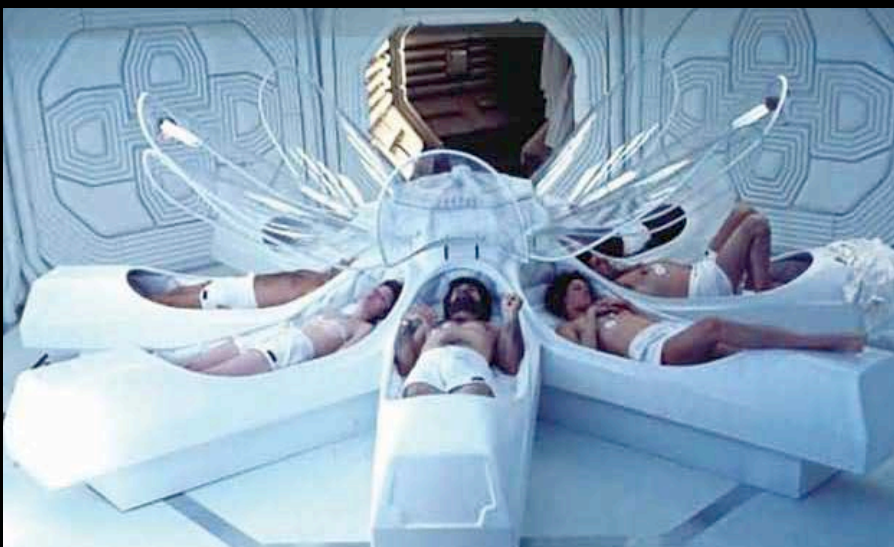
desired destination without traversing all the space in between!

Work and life

Having lived their entire lifespans in space, would such humans still hold true to the classical human values of liberty, peace, friendship, love, unity, and respect of diversity? To be sure, space would teach us a lesson or two about life. High stress levels and constant demands of discipline would lead to almost military-like lifestyles. Humans might be genetically bred to be professionals (pilots, navigators, medics), and insubordination could result in instant death and "recycling". Regular exercise may be mandated by law, and our time awake pre-scheduled by the mission supercomputer running the latest logistics-allocation algorithms. It would be worthwhile to check if the human construct of "family" survives in the lonely corners of space.

The return journey

Returning to our spacefarers aboard the ISC Antriksh, we gaze into their eyes as they bid adieu to their loved ones, and try to understand what would really drive these humans of the future, and what would cause them to "come back home". Would it be mere curiosity that would lead them on this journey, or the need to fix the mess of their forefathers? If we still preserve the notion of a home after exploring the cosmos for a millennia or two, we'd surely want to circle back and see where we came from. Furthermore, will this planet now serve as a pilgrim's destination, similar to how our hometowns, villages and several heritage sites on the Earth currently do. It might be a long, long time before we decide to head back home, and returning in flesh may not be feasible. By then, the human species may have evolved into a man-machine hybrid, by transplanting our souls into more durable containers, to carry our thoughts and aspirations for all posterity. But there is a steep price to pay for all our endeavours, for there is a high chance that over the eons, we might lose all knowledge of Earth's location. So we might as well first start by building an inter-galactic homing beacon that will serve us well in the future yet to come!! 



Human hibernation chambers in a space craft are a pre-requisite for long voyages